and it was well known that if Sulaiman was the chief of Badakhshan, Haram was its ruler. Thus, when Kamran wished for an alliance with Badakhshan – and its army – he did not approach Sulaiman but sent, instead, a proposal of marriage to his wife. As Kamran's messenger woman 'wept, and moaned, and coaxed', pressing his suit upon the queen, Haram sent for her husband and son, thundered at them for being cowards and wondered what a man like Kamran should deserve, 'who fears neither me nor my son'. As for Kamran's proposal – she had his messenger torn from limb to limb.

Thus rebuffed, Kamran began to attack Badakhshan instead of allying with it; and Humayun, still in Kabul, began to make plans to march north in his pursuit – plans interrupted by the sudden defection of several of his chiefs. Among them, inexplicably, was Babus, the man whose sons had been flung at him from Kabul's walls, and whose wife had been thrown to Kabul's bazaar. Does Babus's defection say a great deal for Kamran's charisma, or very little for Humayun's leadership? It's hard to say – and Humayun couldn't do much about it. According to Jouher, he thought of sending Akbar as mediator to the chiefs, 'to make friends of them', but gave up the idea when he was told it might backfire should the chiefs make a hostage of the young ambassador. All Humayun could do in the end was give the defectors rude nicknames: Babus Daiyus (cuckold) being a particularly unkind example.[44]

By the summer of 1548, however, Humayun had rallied enough support to besiege Kamran in the fortress of Taligan, near Badakhshan. The siege lasted a month, during the course of which Sulaiman and his son came to Humayun's aid with their army. According to Gulbadan, the formidable Haram Begum had ridden with her troops some distance before sending them to battle – and win – against her cheeky suitor.

Humayun, on the other hand, was keen to make peace, asking Kamran – 'O evil brother and beloved war-seeker' – to stop and spare a thought for all the unnecessary blood being spilt in their quarrel. Kamran replied valiantly of kingship belonging to he who kisses 'the gleaming . . . lip' of the sword, but when the reinforcements he was expecting didn't arrive, he changed his tune. '[N]ow I repent of the past,' wrote Kamran in a letter that he shot into Humayun's camp on the edge of an arrow. He asked for an envoy to whom